

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

We are deeply grateful to Oxford University Press for their appreciation of the academic, social, and political importance of this book. In particular, we express our sincere gratitude to Claire M. Renzetti, co-editor, with Jeffrey L. Edleson, of the *Interpersonal Violence* book series at Oxford University Press. We had the privilege of working with Dr. Renzetti on the first edition of *From Madness to Mutiny*, when she was the editor of The Northeastern Series on Gender, Crime, and Law. Many years later we reconnected with Dr. Renzetti and proposed a second edition of this book. Her enthusiasm, encouragement, and support for this subject persisted notwithstanding the intervening years. As this topic cries out for a strong response from government, and from society writ large, we are blessed to have a series editor who comprehends the urgency of redressing a criminally dysfunctional family court system that routinely subjugates women and children.

We also wish to acknowledge the entire team of professionals at Oxford University Press. In particular, we express our gratitude to Dana Bliss, Executive Editor at Oxford University Press, who conscientiously shepherded us through each critical stage in bringing this book project to fruition. His patience, support, and encouragement are deeply appreciated. We thank Mary Funchion, our project editor who meticulously attended to all the necessary details and did so with so much cheer. We thank Raja Dharmaraj, project manager at Integra Software Services, for his generous assistance with carefully preparing our manuscript for publication, always remaining calm and respectful during this lengthy and difficult process. In addition, we thank Associate Professor Margaret B. Drew, University of Massachusetts, Dartmouth School of Law, for her meticulous review of our lengthy manuscript. Her insightful,

substantive, and practical editing suggestions were very much appreciated, as it helped to sharpen and clarify the content of this book. Professor Drew's powerful and cogent foreword provides an excellent introduction to the entrenched problems affecting the family courts throughout the country and, in particular, the plight of mothers who appeal to custody judges to protect their children from abuse committed by the other parent.

Lori Sokol, PhD (psychology), an award-winning author, journalist, global speaker, and life coach, who serves as executive director and editor-in-chief of Women's eNews—a preeminent digital news service—deserves special recognition. Employing the highest standards of journalistic integrity, Women's eNews has published a number of thought-provoking op-eds written by freelance contributors who have analyzed the problems in family court from various angles. Dr. Sokol's commitment to this issue is commendable. She has shown courage and conviction in publishing guest opinion editorials that report in painstaking detail on the maladies of the family courts that have damaged the lives of mothers and children. Women's eNews serves as a beacon of light to many protective mothers who closely follow the commentaries published by this outstanding digital news service. And for good reason. Many public officials look toward Women's eNews as the leading platform for women to share their policy views that greatly affect other women, both at home and in the workplace.

Throughout our four-decade-long study of the family court system, we drew inspiration and strength from a number of individuals, across several professional disciplines, who have worked to shed light on family courts' scandalous mistreatment of mothers who seek help for their children who have been sexually abused by the other parent. These men and women are too numerous to thank individually, but special acknowledgment must be given to Jeremiah B. McKenna (now deceased) who served as chief counsel to the New York State Senate Committee on Crime and Correction and as Executive Director of the Policy Sci-

ences Center at Yale Law School. McKenna's tireless efforts (dating back to 1986) to expose the cruelties of the family courts and child welfare agencies had been a source of hope to many despairing mothers. His championing this issue in the early days served as a guiding light to his colleagues in the state legislature and to other government officials around the country. In the early-to-mid 1990s, he met with members of the US Department of Justice, Child Exploitation and Obscenity Section. He had a stellar background as a state prosecutor, appearing on *60 Minutes*, and inspired a character portrayal in the 1973 film *Serpico* for his role in helping to expose widespread police corruption in accepting bribes from businessmen, gamblers, and narcotics dealers.

Sadly, Jeremiah ("Jerry") passed away several years after the publication of the first edition, but his scholarly memoranda and letters to government officials are still cited today. His devoted wife, Nettie, never forgets to send a sweet note to us at the outset of every holiday, both secular and religious. Through her encouraging words, she has kept Jerry's legacy very much alive.

We acknowledge neuropsychologist and family counseling expert Dr. Robert (Bob) Geffner whose vision to educate and enlighten mental health professionals led to his founding of several peer-reviewed publications for the study of child sexual abuse trauma, most notably the *Journal of Child Sexual Abuse*. Spearheading a unique continuing education training program for clinicians that introduces advanced research and clinical methods for assessing and treating intrafamilial (and stranger) child abuse and trauma, Dr. Geffner has made the Institute on Violence, Abuse and Trauma (IVAT) a unique institution for therapists who practice in this field. Dr. Geffner has contributed an excellent preface to this book, explaining in detail how judges, guardians ad litem, mental health experts, lawyers, and others reduce the complexities of parent-child dynamics to a series of tendentious behavioral labels that become reified, taking on a life of their own, often resulting in custody and visitation decisions that are harmful to the abused child.

Among those advocates leading this movement to reform the American family courts are many committed feminist authors and activists who have channeled their frustration and disappointment over the ingrained gender biases in the family court system—causing irreparable harm to children and deep sorrow to their mothers—into healthy and productive activism. Siena psychology professor Maureen “Mo” Therese Hannah became a dedicated proponent of family court reform. Since 2004, she has brought together protective mothers, child advocates, and professionals from all over the country for her annual Battered Mothers Custody Conference (BMCC) at Siena College in Albany, New York. Her tireless efforts and dedication have not waned over time. Her annual conference serves as a nexus for all those concerned about the gender-based injustices and inequities prevalent in the family courts. George Washington University Law School Professor Joan S. Meier serves as an inspiration to mothers trapped in the unjust family court system as well as to researchers and scholars, who appreciate her production of valid and reliable research findings to substantiate the gravity of family court malfunction. Her sincerity and commitment to seeing change is palpable in her many writings in the academic literature and in her keynote addresses at major conferences and symposia.

As director of the National Family Violence Law Center (NFVLC) at George Washington University Law School, Professor Meier helped draft a pivotal provision for the Violence Against Women Act 2022 (VAWA) that would set a nationwide standard for family courts in handling serious child abuse matters under their jurisdiction. Titled “Keeping Children Safe From Family Violence Act” (commonly referred to as “Kayden’s Law”—named after a Bucks County, Pennsylvania, seven-year-old girl, Kayden Mancuso, tragically murdered by her abusive father while on a court-ordered unsupervised visit), this provision, in whole or in part, has already been adopted by seven states in the United States. The provision, which requires a court to consider abuse evidence—both new and old—when making custody and visitation decisions, was signed into

law by President Biden as a section in VAWA in March 2022. A good deal of the legwork for garnering the adoption of this law, and in advocating for the safety of children writ large, was done by NFVLC Policy Manager Danielle Pollack, whose painstaking attention to detail helped make NFVLC a preeminent institution for legislative reform, research, and expert support for child advocates.

As a galvanizing force and as an inspiration to many, one of Professor Meier's study co-authors deserves a special acknowledgment in this book. Former senior social science analyst at the National Institute of Justice, Dr. Leora N. Rosen has taken up the cause of protective mothers with such enthusiasm, devotion, and love that words cannot sufficiently express our gratitude to her. In addition to her scholarly writings on this subject, Dr. Rosen is also a very talented composer and vocalist. She co-wrote a song called "The Milk of Human Kindness"—which captures the essence of the mother-child bond so miserably crushed by a corrupt and jaded court system. With her beautiful soprano voice, Leora performed the song on radio and inspired many mothers to rise up and fight the behemoth of the family courts. We are blessed to have her as an advocate for protective mothers.

Similar to Dr. Rosen, her co-author of *The Hostage Child*, Michelle Etlin, deserves special recognition. Ms. Etlin has devoted her life to helping mothers represent themselves in hostile court settings wherein their attorneys had abandoned them because of lack of funds or pressure from the other side. A truly humble, down-to-earth person, Michelle traveled on Greyhound buses across the country to help countless mothers in remote, small towns fight for their children's safety. She received little to no compensation and often paid for her travel and lodging out-of-pocket. Her goal now is to reunite mothers with children from whom they have been estranged for many years as a result of family court decisions favoring abusive fathers in child custody awards while expunging loving mothers from their children's lives. Her forthcoming memoir, *The Recap: My 40 Years in the Mothers' Movement*, will show her success

stories in reuniting long-estranged children with the mothers they undeservedly lost due to the brutality of the family court system.

Two other women stand out for their amazing support of this issue, although they were neither students of the issue nor victims of the family court system. Instead, as women of color, they had a deep appreciation of what it was like for the protective mothers who suffered the ingrained biases of the family court and child welfare system. They understood all too well how society—with one stroke—can oppress, marginalize, and disenfranchise people of a particular class for no other reason than their membership in that class. The first of these two women is Marian Douglas-Ungaro. As press secretary to Congressman Major Owens (a federal lawmaker representing New York's 12th and then 11th congressional district from 1983–2007 and a strong legislative force in assisting Black colleges that were struggling financially), Ms. Douglas-Ungaro put together a successful political press conference at the Sheraton Manhattan in 1992 to shed light on the plight of mothers in family courts, focusing in particular on a tragic case from Brooklyn's Orthodox Jewish community. Shortly thereafter, she worked with her friend and colleague, USA Today award-winning columnist Barbara Reynolds, to successfully bring that case to worldwide media attention.

The second of these unusual women is Venitra Glass, Administrative Assistant at the Institute for Human Services, an organization of internationally known thought leaders in child welfare policy reform. Venitra generously and wholeheartedly immersed herself in an historical study of a major case of extreme and severe child abuse—entailing a lengthy hospitalization for life-threatening anorexia nervosa, malnutrition, anemia, and suicidal depression—in Brooklyn's Orthodox Jewish community in the late 1980s. Her unwavering belief in a better tomorrow was refreshing. And her encouragement and moral support were invaluable. At every step of the way, Venitra showed sensitivity to the cultural conditions of children raised in religious enclaves where acknowledgment of child abuse is generally discouraged.

Among those we would like to acknowledge is emeritus academic publisher Howard Lipsitz, who, although retired from his stellar career in education technology, offered us a perspicuous analysis of the failed family court system by invoking insightful comparisons with other government and judicial systems. In doing so, he inspired us to excogitate and reflect on the flawed infrastructural substrata of trial courts in general and, in particular, the dangers posed by a sole jurist, who is authorized to decide the fate of abused children, often to their detriment. We would also like to thank Fort Lee, New Jersey, resident Martin Epstein for his courage in speaking up when learning of family courts' atrocious removal of children from loving mothers. As the former president of the Young Israel of Fort Lee, and as a former executive vice president at the Orthodox Union, one of the largest Orthodox Jewish organizations in the United States, Martin expressed concern for the plight of protective mothers across all faiths. In 2022, in responding to a feature story on the corrupt American family court system appearing in *The Jewish Press*, he wrote a poignant Letter to the Editor stating that he “*davened* [prayed] for a reunion . . . for all the mothers across America who have been bereft of their children.”

Activist, educator, and Orthodox community leader Evelyn Haies (Founder of Rachel's Children Reclamation Foundation), who unfortunately succumbed to melanoma before this second edition was completed, determinedly reached out, even in her last years of life, to mothers harmed by the family courts and child welfare system. Evelyn referred their cases to us, as she was resolved to see a solution to this problem and wanted to help in any way she could. Her referrals, in fact, were quite useful to us in shaping our research findings and analyses for this book. Notably, her good work lives on in the pages of this second edition.

We also want to acknowledge, among this group of sympathetic ears, Alan M. Vinegrad, former United States Attorney for the Eastern District of New York, who has consistently shown concern for the plight of children whose fate has been marked by reckless and irresponsible family

court and child welfare agency decisions. As a form of reality testing, in and of itself, it was very helpful to us to see that another person was equally outraged by the dire conditions in the family courts which habitually place mothers and children at risk.

We would like to give special acknowledgment to David Holzel, former managing editor at the *Washington Jewish Week*, who published an op-ed in late summer 2022 by one of the authors of this book. What was remarkable was that when Amy Neustein approached Holzel about her writing a guest column on the plight of protective mothers, he did not fall back on the tried-and-true prejudices and fallacies that “all women lie about sex abuse.” Instead, Holzel was open to learning more about the dire conditions facing mothers in the family courts, and rightfully asked for proper documentation to support those contentions. Looking over the material, he saw the issue had merit and published Neustein’s op-ed. Soon thereafter, her guest column was reprinted in two other Jewish newspapers that were members of the same news consortium as the *Washington Jewish Week*. We knew, then and there, that the protective mothers had found a true angel at this prominent Jewish weekly—a man who undeniably showed compassion rather than skepticism.

And lastly, among our personal circle of friends and neighbors, we acknowledge Sally Share, a remarkable woman who, as a former (used) bookstore owner, has a deep appreciation for the passion and zeal of writers who tackle very difficult subjects. Sally’s kindness, enthusiasm, and grace were indispensable to us in creating an ambiance of safety and calm, which was very much needed to produce a book of this importance, and to help bring an end to the senseless misery visited upon women and children in our nation’s family courts.

A. N. and M. L.

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